

NEXT FOUR BILLION

MAYBE THAT'S WHAT THE COVER STORY SHOULD HAVE BEEN CALLED, BUT IT'S NOT AS CATCHY AS THE HEADLINE WE USED, IS IT?

Robert Sovereign-Smith | robert@digit.in

Over half of the world (4.3 billion people or 56.8 per cent actually) is online already – using payment apps, catching up on entertainment and sports, social media, watching pointless videos or actually using the Internet to gain some knowledge. The other half is where the focus has shifted, and with good reason. It's a mad rush to capture that virgin audience, and to hook them on to services. The profits companies will make off the next 4 billion may be far smaller, but there is a chance to build a monopoly or a niche, which most

companies cannot hope to do with the first 4 billion anymore.

Note: If you're a stickler for math, yes, we're aware that the global population is considered to be 7.7 billion, and that it's well under 4 billion who are still offline, but we're talking about the next decade, and conservative estimates have the population of the world rising to 8.5 billion by 2030. That's how we arrive at 4.3 billion online now, and another 4 billion or so to go.

So who are these billions, and where are they located? One way to do this is to look at Internet penetration stats that are published by various sources, get an average

and subtract the percentages from 100 to arrive at stats for which countries or continents had the most percentages of their populations offline still. So let's do that...

According to internetworldstats.com*, 56.8 per cent of the global population (7,716,223,209 people) is online, which means that 43.2 per cent are still offline. That's a total of 3,332,412,867 people who have not connected to the internet for a variety of reasons. When you break this up by continent, it's pretty much as one would expect.

Asia has a whopping 4.2 billion people overall, and 2 billion are connected, with 2.2 billion still to connect. Africa has 1.3 billion people with 855 million still to